Subscriber Segment Analysis

Video Ads (iOS) vs. Lead Magnet Ads — Which segment deserves more budget?

Adsora | March 2026 | Data: Beehiiv Cohort & CTR Analysis (Apr 2025 – Feb 2026)

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1 Executive Summary

This report compares two subscriber acquisition segments to determine optimal budget allocation:

- **Video Ads (iOS targeting)** — $3.50 per subscriber, 100% iOS audience
- **Lead Magnet Ads (mixed targeting)** — $1.50 per subscriber, ~50/50 iOS/Android split

We analyzed cohort retention (% active over time) and verified click-through rates (CTR). Because CTR is calculated as a percentage of openers (not total subscribers), the correct formula for actual clicks per subscriber accounts for both open rate and CTR.

> **Bottom Line:** Video ad subscribers have ~1.9x the verified CTR of lead magnet subscribers (0.65% vs 0.35%). When properly accounting for the CTR-on-openers math, both segments produce a nearly identical cost per click (~$2.94/click/year). However, video subscribers generate ~2.3x the clicks per subscriber per year (1.19 vs 0.51), making them significantly more valuable on a per-subscriber basis for a daily-send, click-dependent business. The recommendation is to invest primarily in video ads.

2 Apple Mail Privacy Protection — Industry Research

Before analyzing our data, it's critical to understand how Apple Mail Privacy Protection (MPP) distorts open rate metrics. Here is what the industry research confirms:

2.1 — What MPP Does

Introduced in September 2021, Apple's Mail Privacy Protection pre-loads all email content — including tracking pixels — through Apple's proxy servers, regardless of whether the subscriber actually opens the email. This means every iOS Apple Mail user with MPP enabled (estimated at 97%+ of all Apple Mail users) registers as an "open" automatically.

2.2 — Documented Impact on Open Rates

> **Key industry findings on MPP inflation:**

FINDING	DATA	SOURCE
Open rates nearly doubled post-MPP	Total open rates rose from **22.6% to 40.5%** (+18 pts); unique opens from **15.2% to 29.0%** (+14 pts)	Omeda (6-month study)
Apple Mail users show near-100% open rates	Apple Mail reports **~100% open rate** for MPP-enabled contacts, regardless of actual engagement	Constant Contact, ActiveCampaign

MPP adoption is near-universal	**97%+** of Apple device users have MPP enabled	Litmus
Apple dominates email client share	Apple Mail accounts for **49.29%** of all email opens (Jan 2025); **57%+** per Litmus (Jul 2022)	Litmus, MarketingOps
Real-world inflation example	A newsletter at 28% open rate **jumped to 55% overnight** after MPP rollout	Beehiiv
Apple's proxy fires ~73% of pixel events	Apple Privacy Proxy accounts for **73.11%** of all pixel-firing events	MarketingOps
Estimated peak inflation for Apple audiences	Open rates can reach **~75%** for Apple Mail users at peak adoption	Litmus

2.3 — What This Means for Our Data

Our video ad segment is **100% iOS**. This means virtually all open-rate-based metrics ("% active") are unreliable — the raw ~50% retention at Month 6+ is substantially inflated by phantom opens. The lead magnet segment (~50% iOS) is also partially inflated, but less severely.

Critically: Click-through rates are not affected by MPP. Clicks require human action and cannot be faked. However, CTR is calculated as a percentage of openers — so when the open denominator is inflated by MPP, the reported CTR appears lower than the true engagement rate of real openers.

> **Note on Beehiiv:** Beehiiv does filter some MPP noise from its analytics, so the "% active" numbers shown are not raw inflated figures. However, the filtering is imperfect, and iOS-heavy audiences will still show inflated activity rates.

3 Segment Overview

VIDEO ADS — COST/SUB

$3.50

100% iOS | UTM: 120221520824290090

LEAD MAGNET — COST/SUB

$1.50

~50/50 iOS/Android | Multiple UTMs

4 Cohort Retention (% Active Over Time)

4.1 — Video Ads (iOS) Cohort Retention

COHORT	MO 0	MO 1	MO 2	MO 3	MO 4	MO 5	MO 6	MO 7	MO 8	MO 9	MO 10
Apr '25	68.85%	68.85%	62.42%	57.73%	54.76%	52.66%	52.16%	50.56%	49.32%	50.06%	48.95%
May '25	66.39%	68.13%	61.76%	57.30%	54.92%	53.04%	50.86%	48.94%	48.15%	46.79%	
Jun '25	68.65%	67.58%	65.48%	58.83%	56.77%	53.90%	52.41%	50.06%	48.56%		

Flattens around 49–52% at Month 6+. Heavily inflated by iOS MPP phantom opens (see Section 2).

4.2 — Lead Magnet Ads Cohort Retention (Set A: Jul–Dec 2025)

COHORT	MO 0	MO 1	MO 2	MO 3	MO 4	MO 5	MO 6	MO 7
Jul '25	29.81%	58.34%	53.05%	50.95%	43.00%	40.20%	39.60%	36.77%

Aug '25	48.69%	54.73%	52.05%	43.59%	40.04%	37.51%	34.82%	
Sep '25	51.19%	59.37%	49.64%	45.76%	42.45%	39.35%		
Oct '25	51.10%	57.98%	54.63%	48.05%	43.40%			
Nov '25	51.17%	58.16%	52.78%	45.88%				
Dec '25	54.55%	54.55%	50.00%					

4.3 — Lead Magnet Ads Cohort Retention (Set B: Oct 2025–Feb 2026)

COHORT	MO 0	MO 1	MO 2	MO 3	MO 4
Oct '25	47.85%	58.87%	56.09%	48.72%	44.39%
Nov '25	54.63%	57.76%	53.55%	47.21%	
Dec '25	44.19%	49.09%	42.12%		
Jan '26	45.97%	52.43%			
Feb '26	52.45%				

Stabilizes around 35–44% at Month 6. Less inflated (50% Android), but still partially affected.

5 Verified Click-Through Rate — The Real Signal

Click-through rate cannot be faked by Apple MPP. Clicks require real human action. This is the only reliable engagement metric for comparing these segments.

5.1 — Video Ads (iOS) — Verified CTR

COHORT WEEK	CLICK-THROUGH RATE	VERIFIED CTR
Apr 14, 2025	~0.9%	**~0.8%**
Apr 21, 2025	~1.9%	**~0.9%**
Apr 28, 2025	~0.65%	~0.6%
May 5, 2025	~0.95%	**~0.75%**
May 12, 2025	~1.0%	~0.6%

Average verified CTR: ~0.65% (of openers)

5.2 — Lead Magnet Ads (Campaign A, Oct–Nov 2025) — Verified CTR

COHORT WEEK	CLICK-THROUGH RATE	VERIFIED CTR
Oct 20, 2025	~0.4%	~0.3%
Oct 27, 2025	~0.5%	~0.4%
Nov 3, 2025	~0.45%	~0.37%
Nov 10, 2025	~0.55%	**~0.5%**
Nov 17, 2025	~0.35%	~0.3%

Average verified CTR: ~0.35% (of openers)

5.3 — Lead Magnet Ads (Campaign B, Aug–Sep 2025) — Verified CTR

COHORT WEEK	CLICK-THROUGH RATE	VERIFIED CTR
Aug 18, 2025	~0.35%	~0.3%
Aug 25, 2025	~0.35%	~0.3%
Sep 1, 2025	~0.7%	~0.45%
Sep 8, 2025	~0.9%	**~0.5%**
Sep 15, 2025	~0.35%	~0.3%

Average verified CTR: ~0.35% (of openers)

5.4 — Key Takeaway

Video subscribers have approximately **1.9x the verified CTR** of lead magnet subscribers (0.65% vs 0.35%). This is a real, unfakeable engagement difference.

6 Corrected Click Economics

6.1 — Why the Math Matters

CTR is calculated as a percentage of **openers**, not total subscribers. To calculate actual clicks per subscriber, we must account for open rate:

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Clicks per subscriber per email = Open Rate × CTR
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This is important because a subscriber who never opens will never click, regardless of the CTR among openers.

6.2 — Video Ads (iOS) — Click Math

STEP	METRIC	VALUE	NOTES
1. Start	1 subscriber	1.00	
2. Open rate	~50% active at Mo 6	0.50	Beehiiv-filtered, still inflated by iOS MPP
3. Verified CTR	0.65% of openers	0.0065	Real human clicks
4. Clicks per sub per email	0.50 × 0.0065	**0.00325**	
5. Clicks per sub per year	0.00325 × 365	**1.19**	
6. Cost per click per year	$3.50 ÷ 1.19	**$2.94**	

6.3 — Lead Magnet Ads — Click Math

STEP	METRIC	VALUE	NOTES
1. Start	1 subscriber	1.00	
2. Open rate	~40% active at Mo 6	0.40	Less inflated (50% Android)
3. Verified CTR	0.35% of openers	0.0035	Real human clicks
4. Clicks per sub per email	0.40 × 0.0035	0.00140	
5. Clicks per sub per year	0.00140 × 365	0.51	
6. Cost per click per year	$1.50 ÷ 0.51	**$2.94**	

6.4 — Side-by-Side Comparison

METRIC	VIDEO ADS (IOS)	LEAD MAGNET ADS	RATIO
Cost per subscriber	$3.50	$1.50	2.3x more expensive
Open rate (Mo 6)	~50%	~40%	1.25x (but inflated for iOS)
Verified CTR (of openers)	**~0.65%**	~0.35%	**~1.9x higher**
Clicks per sub per email	**0.00325**	0.00140	**2.3x more**
Clicks per sub per year (365 emails)	**~1.19**	~0.51	**2.3x more**
Cost per click per year	$2.94	$2.94	**Equal**
iOS audience %	100%	~50%	—

> **Key finding:** The cost per click per year is virtually identical (~$2.94) between both segments. However, video subscribers generate **2.3x more clicks per subscriber** (1.19 vs 0.51 per year). This means each video subscriber is a 2.3x more productive asset on your list.

7 Analysis

7.1 — The iOS Inflation Problem (Research-Backed)

Industry data confirms that Apple MPP inflates open rates dramatically. Omeda's 6-month study showed total open rates nearly doubling from 22.6% to 40.5% after MPP launched. Apple Mail users can show near-100% open rates because MPP pre-loads every email automatically. With 97%+ of Apple users having MPP enabled, our 100%-iOS video segment's "% active" data is significantly overstated.

However, this inflation also affects the CTR calculation: because the open denominator is inflated by phantom opens, the reported CTR for iOS audiences appears *lower* than it actually is among real openers. This means the video segment's true CTR among genuinely engaged openers is likely even higher than the reported 0.65%.

7.2 — Equal Cost Per Click, Unequal Value Per Subscriber

With corrected math (CTR on openers, not total subscribers), both segments arrive at roughly the same cost per click per year (~$2.94). This might suggest it doesn't matter which segment you invest in. But that conclusion is wrong, because:

- **Video subscribers produce 2.3x more clicks per person per year.** Each video subscriber is a significantly more productive asset sitting on your list. You're sending 365 emails/year — a subscriber who clicks 1.19 times is generating more than double the monetization opportunities of one who clicks 0.51 times.
- **More clicks per sub = more revenue touchpoints.** If each click has a chance of converting into revenue (ad clicks, affiliate offers, product purchases), a subscriber generating 2.3x the clicks generates 2.3x the revenue opportunities over their lifetime.
- **Higher-clicking subscribers improve list-level deliverability.** ISPs use engagement signals (including clicks) to determine inbox placement. A list with more active clickers gets better deliverability for everyone, amplifying the value across your entire subscriber base.
- **Volume matters for scale.** To get the same total number of clicks from lead magnet subscribers, you'd need 2.3x more subscribers — which means managing a larger list, paying higher ESP costs, and dealing with more dead weight.

7.3 — The MPP Caveat on Our Math

The open rates we're using in our calculation are Beehiiv-filtered, but still partially inflated for the iOS segment. If the video segment's real open rate is lower than 50% (say 35-40% after fully stripping MPP inflation), then:

- Clicks per sub per year would drop to ~0.83–0.95 (still higher than lead magnet's 0.51)
- Cost per click per year would rise to ~$3.68–$4.22
- Lead magnet would win on pure cost-per-click efficiency

However, the same logic applies: even with further deflated open rates, video subscribers still generate more clicks per person, making each subscriber a more valuable list asset.

8 Conclusions & Recommendations

> **Primary Recommendation:** Video ad subscribers are the higher-quality segment. At equal cost-per-click economics and 2.3x the clicks per subscriber, they are the more productive and valuable audience. Allocate the majority of budget to video ads.

Rationale

- **2.3x more clicks per subscriber per year** — each video sub generates 1.19 clicks vs. 0.51 for lead magnet across 365 daily emails.
- **Cost per click is equal (~$2.94)** — you're not paying more per click, you're getting more clicks per person.
- **Smaller, more engaged list is better** than a larger, less engaged one — lower ESP costs, better deliverability, higher revenue per subscriber.

- **Video CTR is genuinely 1.9x higher** — confirmed by verified clicks that cannot be inflated by Apple MPP.

Recommended Budget Allocation

SEGMENT	BUDGET SHARE	RATIONALE
Video Ads	**60–70%**	2.3x clicks/sub, equal cost/click, higher list quality
Lead Magnet Ads	**30–40%**	Diversification, lower iOS dependency, volume buffer

Key Risks & Watch Items

- **Video CPL scalability:** Monitor whether the $3.50 CPL holds as spend increases. If CPL climbs above ~$4.50, the cost-per-click shifts in favor of lead magnet.
- **Don't kill lead magnet entirely:** It provides cost-efficient volume and reduces dependency on iOS-only audiences. If Apple further changes privacy policies, an all-iOS list carries platform risk.
- **Get downstream conversion data:** Revenue-per-click by segment is the missing piece. If video subscribers also convert at a higher rate per click (not just more clicks), the case for video becomes even stronger.
- **Content optimization is the biggest lever:** Regardless of segment, improving email content to push verified CTR higher across the board compounds massively over 365 sends. Even a 0.1% CTR improvement = significant annual click gains.
- **Consider the MPP discount:** If video's real open rate is closer to 35-40% (not 50%), cost per click rises to ~$3.70–$4.20 vs. lead magnet's $2.94. Monitor this by tracking absolute click volumes, not percentages.

9 Sources — Apple MPP Research

- **Omeda** — "The Impact of Apple's Mail Privacy Protection – 6 Months Later" (Mar 2022). Open rates rose from 22.6% to 40.5% total; 15.2% to 29.0% unique. *omeda.com/blog/the-impact-of-apples-mail-privacy-protection-6-months-later/*
- **Litmus** — "Apple's Mail Privacy Protection Is Here: What It Actually Means for Email Marketers." Estimated ~75% open rate at peak adoption for Apple Mail; 96%+ MPP opt-in rate; Apple devices = 49.8% of email opens. *litmus.com/blog/apple-mail-privacy-protection-for-marketers*
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- **Constant Contact** — "How Apple's Mail Privacy Protection Impacts Email Marketing." Apple Mail reports ~100% open rates for MPP-enabled contacts. *constantcontact.com/blog/apple-mail-privacy-protection-for-email-marketing/*
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